have taken the bodies to the river bank," he said gently. "Come, you must perform the last rites before sunset. Tomorrow, we will go back to Pauri."

I had last seen my family while leaving for Pauri. They stood at the doorway and waved. Ma, Grandma, Nilu and Bhuli. That is the way I will always remember them – smiling and waving at me. Not as the white-shrouded lifeless figures I saw.

Bhuli? She was not there.

"They have not found her," my uncle said. "The wild animals …Brij, don't look like that! She is dead."

"But we must find her," I shouted.

"Brij…get a grip on yourself," uncle pleaded.

But I was beyond reasoning. I ran back to the village, to the spot where my house had stood.

There was still so much debris. I scrambled around shifting the earth and stones. How long I was on my knees searching, crying, searching…

"Boy, it is no use" a voice said. I looked up. The speaker was the Army Officer who had supervised the relief operation. "There is no one alive in there," he said, "whom are you looking for?"

"My sister, Sir," I said, fighting to control my tears, "All I want is to give her a proper cremation."

I stopped, conscious that I was babbling. I could see that he was bone-tired. He looked as if he had not slept for days. His uniform was covered with dust, his face was grimy. But through all the dust and grime, I saw that his eyes were kind.

"My men have been on their feet for days," he said softly, as if talking to himself. "They have done all they could here. Tomorrow, at daybreak, we go to another village just like this, then another. He looked away at the sun setting behind the peaks. Down, in the valley, the pyres burnt, row upon row. The officer muttered something, shook his head and turned away. A terrible despair engulfed me. I lay there among the ruins of my house and cried.

Ten minutes later, the officer was back. With him were three soldiers armed with spades and crowbars. Without a word, the men began, removing the debris. They laboured doggedly. When it was completely dark, someone brought a few lit petromax lamps. Two hours later, a soldier called out, "Sir!"

He stood in the middle of a small hollow. The wall had caved in at that spot. I recognized a part of a door. Beneath it, a small foot.

Feverishly the soldiers began to clear the hollow. Then, they lifted the door.

"She is alive!" someone said.

It was a miracle. She had been buried under the debris for a hundred and sixteen hours. She had survived the earthquake, the cold nights and the

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